appearance, at Headingley in 1993. Lathwell was known on the circuit as ‘The Natural’, a Somerset batsman touched by genius. ‘Good luck,’ said Atherton. ‘The crowd are rooting for you.’ Lathwell shot back: ‘They won’t be in a minute when I’m on my way back.’

Sure enough, he was dismissed third ball. He loathed the fanfare, loved nothing more than a game of darts in the pub. He retired prematurely and is still spoken of as one of the great wasted talents. Alec Stewart, a consistently shrewd judge of character, believes that, of his generation of England cricketers, Lathwell was the only player who ‘just didn’t want to be there’.

Being alone, when your opening partner has been dismissed three balls into an Ashes Test match, is a disconcerting experience. When that happened to me at Brisbane at the start of the 2010 tour, it triggered another tidal wave of noise, with an entirely different tone. Straussy held his head in his hands after being caught in the gully by Mike Hussey off Ben Hilfenhaus.

I could see him thinking, ‘What have I done? *What have I done? ’* He carried the responsibility of captaincy like a concrete overcoat. It was a nothing ball, delivered in an area that Ricky Ponting acknowledged played to Straussy’s strengths, but was fractionally too close to his body to safely attempt the cut shot.

No words were necessary, though they would have been impossible to hear, in any case. The Gabbatoir was living up to its reputation. There was something primeval about the tribal howl that accompanied him back to the pavilion. I turned and looked at the mob scene of Australian players at the other end of the pitch and felt like the loneliest man alive.

Everything is built up to that first ball, that first over. Brain fades, such as Steve Harmison’s opening delivery in 2006, which went straight to second slip, enter folklore. While I was waiting for Jonathan Trott to join me, I was thinking, ‘Nought for one. Big series. Oh my God.’ I suspect I fooled no one with my stilted attempts to radiate inner peace while practising a forward defensive.

Here’s the funny thing: my mind was very clear. The Gimp never takes a day off, but I had him under control. I didn’t have to listen to his snide whispers, his mocking insinuations. He had been hammering me, but I simply stepped around him. I knew he would still try to cause me grief